ENGLISH I · WEEK 1

English I week 1 rules: Sounds and pronunciation

Vowel sounds · Diphthongs · Consonants, clusters & glides. Save this PDF for revision.

VOWEL SOUNDS · IN EVERY PAPER

Short vowels

Symbol	IPA	As in	Words from past papers
i	/ɪ/	sit	pit, kit, knit, lit, mitt
e	/e/	bed	wet, pen
a	/æ/	cat	pack, man
o	/ɒ/	hot	bottle, pot
u	/ʊ/	put	foot, book, good
ʌ	/ʌ/	cup	but, love, son
ə (schwa)	/ə/	about	sofa, teacher (unstressed syllables)

VOWEL SOUNDS · IN EVERY PAPER

Long vowels: the letter is doubled

Symbol	IPA	As in	Words from past papers
ii	/iː/	seat	meet, lead, wheat, neat, feet, bleat
aa	/ɑː/	car	hard, father, start
oo	/ɔː/	law	court, board, hoard, sport, ball
uu	/uː/	food	root, loot, moot, blue, too, flew, through
əə	/ɜː/	bird	her, word, learn

VOWEL SOUNDS · IN EVERY PAPER

Common traps

- Spelling lies: 'oo' in foot is short u /ʊ/, but in food and root it's long uu /uː/.
- The course's oo is the vowel in law, court and board, not the one in food.
- Odd one out by vowel: knit, pit, kit vs neat; lit, mitt, knit vs feet. The long ii word is the odd one.
- All of through, blue, too and flew carry uu (PYQ May 2023: 'All of these').

DIPHTHONGS · IN EVERY PAPER

Key points

- A diphthong glides from one vowel to another inside one syllable (b-oy, m-ou-th). A pure vowel holds still (sp-or-t, m-oo-t).

DIPHTHONGS · IN EVERY PAPER

The 8 diphthongs

Symbol	IPA	Examples
ei	/eɪ/	day, bail, maiden, wake, cake
ai	/aɪ/	my, bite, fly, tired
oi	/ɔɪ/	boy, boycott, loiter, coin
ou	/əʊ/	go, boat, coach, both, know
au	/aʊ/	now, mouth, south, shout, snout, stout, pout
iə	/ɪə/	near, dear, here, gear, shear
eə	/eə/	hair, pear, care, bear
uə	/ʊə/	tour, cure, pure

DIPHTHONGS · IN EVERY PAPER

Common traps

⚠ Tip: Say the vowel slowly. If your jaw or tongue moves during it, it's a diphthong. If it stays put, it isn't.

CONSONANTS, CLUSTERS & GLIDES · IN EVERY PAPER

Place of articulation (this decides 'odd one out by initial sound')

Place	Sounds	Example words
Bilabial (both lips)	p, b, m, w	peat, beat, pear, man, wet
Labiodental (lip + teeth)	f, v	fan, van, phone
Dental (tongue + teeth)	θ, ð	thin, this
Alveolar (tongue + ridge behind teeth)	t, d, n, s, z, l, r	town, down, noun, near, dear, tear, sun

CONSONANTS, CLUSTERS & GLIDES · IN EVERY PAPER

Place of articulation (this decides 'odd one out by initial sound')

Place	Sounds	Example words
Post-alveolar	ʃ, ʒ, tʃ, dʒ	she, measure, church, judge
Palatal	j (written /y/)	yes, you
Velar (back of tongue + soft palate)	k, g, ŋ	gown, gear, clear, king, sing
Glottal	h	hat

CONSONANTS, CLUSTERS & GLIDES · IN EVERY PAPER

Manner of articulation

Manner	Sounds
Plosive (stop, then burst)	p b t d k g
Nasal (air through the nose)	m n ŋ
Fricative (friction)	f v θ ð s z ʃ ʒ h
Affricate (stop + friction)	tʃ dʒ
Approximant	l r w j
Voiceless / voiced pairs	p/b, t/d, k/g, f/v, s/z, θ/ð, ʃ/ʒ, tʃ/dʒ

CONSONANTS, CLUSTERS & GLIDES · IN EVERY PAPER

Linking glides between words

/w/ glide

after u, uu, ou, au (rounded lips) + a vowel

go‿out → go-w-out (PYQ Sep 2023) · do‿it · who‿is

/y/ glide

after i, ii, ei, ai, oi (spread lips) + a vowel

she‿offered → she-y-offered (PYQ Jan 2024) · me‿off (PYQ May 2024) · I‿am · they‿are

CONSONANTS, CLUSTERS & GLIDES · IN EVERY PAPER

Key points

- Consonant cluster: two or more consonants together in one syllable with no vowel between: clear, street, spring, text (PYQ: TRUE).
- Compare first sounds, not letters: knit starts with /n/, city with /s/, chemistry with /k/, phone with /f/.
- Silent letters: knit, write, thumb, hour, listen, psychology.
- Phone numbers: any clear grouping works (86/37/68/11/34, 863/768/113/4, 8637/6811/34). Say 'double 1' for 11. PYQ answer: 'All of these'.

Notes for every week of English I, free.

Full notes, the rule sheet and common traps, with worked PYQs.

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